THE DAILY BRIEF

OCTOBER 21, 2026

AI & TECH

Latest in artificial intelligence, models, and technology

SpaceX's AI business just dethroned Starlink as its biggest revenue stream. SpaceX (Nasdaq: SPCX) reported Q3 revenue of **$14.6 billion, up 161% year-over-year**, beating the LSEG consensus of $12.72 billion. The "Super Intelligence" segment — its AI compute and software business, including the recently-acquired Cursor IDE and the Grok Bot app — pulled in **$7.56 billion** for the quarter, eclipsing Starlink Connectivity ($5.25B) for the first time. Net income hit $4.4 billion versus a $1.1 billion loss a year ago, and Adjusted EBITDA reached $8.8 billion, up 306%. Capex, however, ran a punishing $19.6 billion — almost all of it AI infrastructure — leaving free cash flow negative. (Investing.com / SEC 10-Q)

OpenAI buys a biotech company and pitches a 1.4-trillion-dollar valuation. OpenAI announced Tuesday it is acquiring Orchestra Bio, a startup building AI tools for biological research, marking the lab's most explicit bet yet on life sciences. The same week, multiple outlets reported OpenAI is in the market for **at least $30 billion in new funding** at a roughly **$1.4 trillion valuation** — a number that would dwarf every private company in history other than a handful of state oil giants. Separately, ChatGPT shipped "locked chats" on October 20 and OpenAI's DevDay recap lists 20+ announcements across ChatGPT, Codex, and new agents. (TechCrunch / OpenAI Blog / CNBC)

Anthropic wants laws that can pull a model off the market. Anthropic has begun pitching state legislators on an AI safety bill that would allow regulators to **block the deployment of a frontier model if credible analysis suggests it could cause 50 or more deaths**. The proposal lands in the same week Anthropic told the New York City Council — under oath — that frontier-model labs are "gambling with our lives." Anthropic also disclosed three new technical defenses it says have cut data harvesting by distillation attacks by **90–99%**, while Google, OpenAI, and Anthropic continue to coordinate on a self-regulatory safety body called SAFA, targeted for late 2026 or early 2027. (TechCrunch / Anthropic Research)

MARKETS & FINANCE

Major market moves and financial news

The Dow closed up 1% on earnings beats and an oil cooldown. Stocks diverged Tuesday as 3M rallied **5.8%** after raising its full-year profit forecast and expanding its data-center partnership with Amazon. The S&P; 500 added 0.3% to **7,712.57**, the Dow Jones gained 529 points to **52,495**, and the Nasdaq slipped 6 points to **26,424** as AI-linked names continued to churn after last week's worst week since June. Brent crude fell 0.7% to **$108.79** after briefly touching $112 — a near-term relief valve for airlines and any company with a fuel bill. (AP / EconoTimes)

The biggest AI deal of the day wasn't about chips — it was CRM. Salesforce announced it will acquire customer-engagement platform **Braze for $47.50 a share in cash**, sending Braze's stock up 51.7% to $45.57. The deal

underlines a pattern quietly forming across the quarter: legacy software incumbents are paying up to bolt AI-features-on-top into their stacks rather than rebuild from the ground up. (Vindicator / AP)

The Fed goes quiet for a week ahead of its October 28 decision. The Federal Reserve entered its pre-meeting blackout period on October 17. After a quarter-point hike on September 16 — its first since July 2023 — the federal funds rate sits at **3.75–4.00%**. CME FedWatch puts the odds of another October hike at **17.2%**, with a December move now more likely. The September PCE inflation print lands October 29, the day after the decision. (Yahoo Finance / Political.org)

Crypto bounced as $527 million flowed back into Bitcoin ETFs. Bitcoin traded near **$83,300** Wednesday morning, up 1.3% on the day, while Ethereum hovered around **$2,460**, up 1.7%. The move came after U.S. spot Bitcoin ETFs recorded **$526.7 million in net inflows** on October 19, with BlackRock's IBIT alone pulling in **$665.2 million** — its biggest day since October 2025. Ether ETFs, however, bled for the fourth straight day with **$103.3 million in outflows**. Bitcoin traders are watching the $83,200–$83,600 resistance band; a clean break opens $84,000. (Yahoo Finance / SoSoValue)

BRIEFLY

‹ **SpaceX–Tesla "special committees":** Elon Musk confirmed Tuesday that SpaceX and Tesla have formed committees to evaluate a potential merger, though he played down near-term chances. Tesla shares reacted; SpaceX's lockup expiry Thursday will put roughly **1.3 billion shares** — about 28% of the main restricted pool — into free trading. (Ars Technica / Yahoo)

‹ **Meta quietly edits its TOS:** Meta dropped the word "train" from its commercial terms of service after backlash over whether customer content was being used to train AI models. (Ars Technica)

‹ **Microsoft's next console:** A Microsoft Project Helix leak reportedly pegs the 2028 hardware at a **$1,200–$1,800** price tag. (Ars Technica)

‹ **PHP emergency patches:** The PHP project warned maintainers to prepare for **two imminent critical security releases**. (Ars Technica)

THE TAKEAWAY

The through-line today is that AI is no longer a sector inside the market — it is the market. SpaceX's "Super Intelligence" unit out-earned the company's iconic Starlink business for the first time, OpenAI is raising money at a valuation bigger than the GDP of Switzerland, and Salesforce just paid $47.50 a share to bolt AI features onto a 10-year-old marketing platform. Even the Fed's careful, slow walk toward another rate hike is being driven by an economy where compute spending is the single largest industrial investment cycle since the railroads. The Fed meeting a week from today will set the temperature; what corporate America has already decided is that AI infrastructure is what they're spending on while they wait for it.

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